A Care Decision Is Coming and the Family Doesn't Agree

The first three things to do, in order, and what can wait until afterward.

There's a care decision in front of the family, and everyone has arrived with an answer. Nobody has written down the question yet.

Before anyone compares options, do these three things, in this order.

1 Ask your loved one what they want now

Ask what matters to them about what happens next: what they want to keep, and what worries them. Write the answers down in their own words, with the date, even if it's only a sentence or two. [1] [2]

WHY THIS COMES BEFORE THE OPTIONS Every other opinion in the family is an opinion about them. Their own words belong on the page before anyone else's.

2 Write the decision down in one sentence

“What are we going to do?” isn't a decision yet. Write the real one as a single plain sentence, with the date if there is one, and send it to everyone involved before you meet. Ask whether it's the sentence they would have written. [3]

WHY THIS COMES BEFORE THE OPTIONS A named decision shows which facts it rests on, and which of those the family doesn't have yet.

3 List where you agree and where you don't

Ask each relative involved the same two things: what are you most worried about, and what do you hope for? Then write two short lists, where we agree and where we don't, in words each person would recognize as their own. Leave the second list unsettled. [3]

WHY THIS COMES BEFORE THE OPTIONS You don't need everyone to agree before you meet. You need a page that shows honestly where things stand, so that one strong voice isn't taken for the whole family's.

What can wait until afterward

- Which option is best.
- Comparing particular places, services or schedules.
- Who is right.
- Getting everyone to agree. An honest list of what's unsettled is enough to begin with.
- What kind of care fits your loved one. That takes an assessment by people who see them, and what you've written is what you bring to it.

If you're worried about their health today

That isn't a question for the family meeting. The National Institute on Aging's advice, when you're concerned about a person's physical or mental health, is to suggest a visit to a health care provider. In an emergency, call emergency services.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle the disagreement, choose between options, or say what's right for your loved one. It puts the first three moves in order.

Ready for the next step?

You've asked your loved one, named the decision and written down where the family stands. The care interview sets that beside a full account of your loved one's situation, one area at a time, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The advice to ask your loved one directly, and to suggest a visit to a health care provider when you're concerned about their health, follows the National Institute on Aging. Keeping to their own words follows the Institute for Healthcare Improvement's guidance for care teams. Sending the question out before a meeting and giving everyone a chance to be heard follow the Family Caregiver Alliance's advice on family meetings. The three moves and their order are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
2. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting